MA ENGLISH • SEMESTER 1

Block 1 — Unit 3: Drama - Historical Development

MILTON TO THE PRE-ROMANTICS • M21EG03DC

Expanded exam notes | Simple teaching + developed argument

Based on the supplied SGOU self-learning material. Use the assigned primary texts for exact quotations and full scene or passage analysis.

The chapter in one sentence

Drama changes through classical inheritance, reopened theatres, heroic conflict, fashionable social satire, and disputes about laughter and moral feeling.

Start with a picture

A stage can make a grand ruler’s dilemma or an ordinary fashionable conversation equally revealing. What changes is the kind of action, style, and audience response the play organises.

1. Milton’s dramatic writing

Comus is a masque that combines poetry, music, spectacle, and moral testing. Samson Agonistes draws on classical tragic form and a biblical story. It is often discussed as closet drama, designed primarily for reading, though it has a performance history.

Do not equate dramatic writing only with the commercial London stage or assume that “closet” means a work can never be performed.

2. Restoration conditions

The reopening of public theatres after 1660 changed professional opportunities. Patents, court connections, indoor venues, scenic practices, and the presence of actresses affected production and audiences. Earlier English public companies had generally assigned female roles to boys or men.

A new institution does not automatically create one political message, but it changes what can be staged and how spectators encounter it.

3. Heroic drama

Dryden’s heroic drama often explores honour, love, command, and exceptional conflict in elevated language, sometimes rhymed heroic couplets. Characters face competing obligations expressed with rhetorical intensity.

The form can make authority impressive while also exposing its instability. Use a particular conflict instead of defining heroic drama as simply a story with a brave man.

4. Comedy of manners

Wit, fashionable behaviour, sexual politics, marriage, and property are central. Characters perform social identities and judge one another's style. Congreve's The Way of the World is a major example.

Laughter can expose hypocrisy without necessarily abolishing the hierarchy that gives wit its social value. Ask who can speak cleverly and whose security depends on money or reputation.

5. Sentimental comedy

Sentimental comedy gives sympathy, moral feeling, and exemplary conduct a strong place. Steele's The Conscious Lovers is an important example. This emphasis prompted debate about whether comedy should chiefly teach through tenderness or expose folly through laughter.

6. Later comic responses

Goldsmith and Sheridan renew energetic comic exposure in the eighteenth century. The School for Scandal appeared in 1777, not in the initial Restoration decades. It inherits and revises the comedy-of-manners tradition rather than belonging to precisely the same historical moment.

Quick check

1. Is a masque identical to an ordinary spoken play? **No.**
2. Does comedy of manners only mean elegant costumes? **No; social codes and power matter.**
3. Is Sheridan's 1777 play an early Restoration production? **No.**

Build an exam answer

1. Distinguish Milton's dramatic forms.
2. Explain production changes after 1660.
3. Contrast heroic drama and manners comedy.
4. Describe sentimental comedy's aim.
5. Evaluate later comic responses with correct chronology.

Common mistake to avoid

Do not collapse a literary tradition into one date or assume that making an audience laugh necessarily produces social equality.

Developed exam discussion

Practice question

Explain how dramatic forms produce different relationships between entertainment and moral judgement.

Explain the argument in fuller paragraphs

Drama across the period offers several ways of organising judgement. Milton’s dramatic works draw on biblical and classical materials to create moral trials, while Restoration theatrical institutions support new forms of professional performance. The relation between entertainment and ethical thought changes with these forms rather than following one fixed rule.

Heroic drama gives exceptional conflicts an elevated verbal scale. Comedy of manners works through social interaction, making wit and appearance part of the contest over status. The spectator’s pleasure may expose pretension, but it can also depend on recognising an exclusive code. An answer should therefore consider both the critical force and the social limits of laughter.

Sentimental comedy introduces a different emphasis on sympathy and morally exemplary conduct. Later writers such as Goldsmith and Sheridan challenge the dominance of that mode by renewing comic exposure. The disagreement concerns how a play can teach, please, and position an audience—not whether morality suddenly disappears.

A good comparison connects the form’s language, staging, and ending with a particular response. It also respects chronology: a late-eighteenth-century play can inherit Restoration methods without becoming a work first produced under Charles II.

Use the discussion well

Answer the exact question, not every possible topic. Make one clear point per paragraph, support it with a textual detail or a relevant classroom example, and explain its significance. Check exact quotations against the assigned text. The discussion is paraphrase and guidance, not a quotation or a guaranteed exam answer.

Textbook assignment checklist

The following numbered prompts are retained from the unit for revision. Obvious source errors are discussed in the coverage review; a prompt’s assumptions should not be accepted automatically. These are not predictions or complete written assignments.

1. What were the reasons that prevented Milton from writing more dramas? Discuss.
2. Write a note on Dryden’s heroic drama.
3. Explain the development of the Comedy of Manners by discussing its key figures.
4. Expand the concept that the Sentimental Comedy as a reaction against the Comedy of Manners.